

Referendum 2026 — Voter Churn: Drop-off & Surge

Who left and who arrived between the 2025 General and the April 21, 2026 referendum · DPVA · 2026-05-21

80%

of 2025 General voters returned
(3,434,884 total)

690,881

dropped off — voted 2025G, skipped
referendum (20%)

332,415

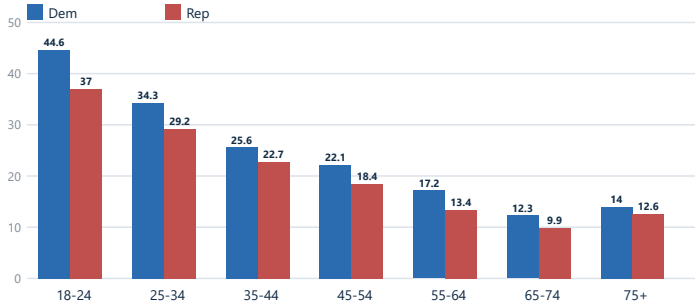
surged in — voted referendum,
skipped 2025G (11%)

-358,466

net change vs 2025G (VAN-matched)

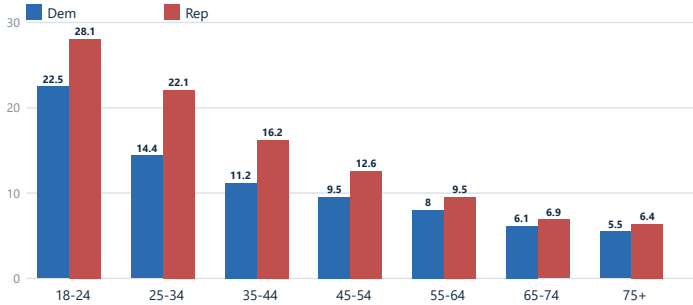
Drop-off rate by age & party

% of each band's 2025G voters who skipped the referendum — Dem vs Rep



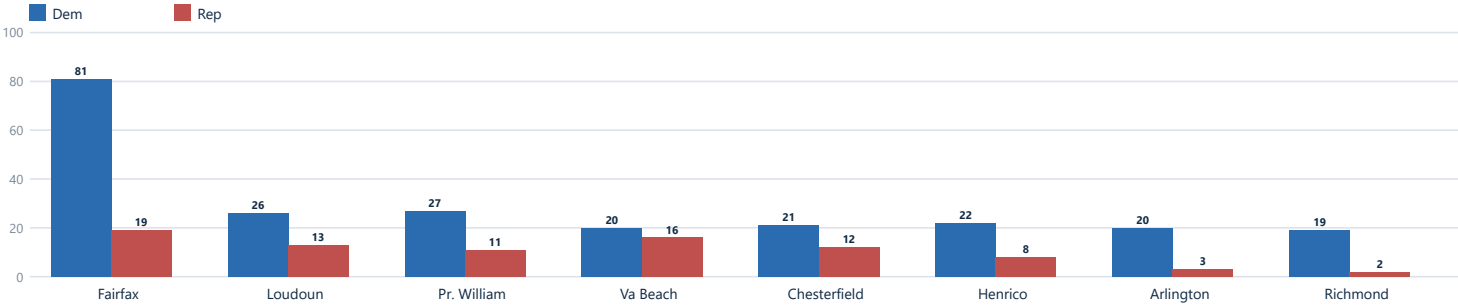
Surge rate by age & party

% of each band's referendum voters who skipped 2025G — Dem vs Rep



Where the lost voters are — top localities by drop-off count & party

thousands of 2025G voters who didn't return — Dem vs Rep



What it means

- Drop-off skews young and Democratic — at every age.** Democrats dropped off more than Republicans in every band (overall 22% vs 17%), widest among the young: 45% of Dem 18–24s vs 37% of Rep. The Yes win came *despite* losing more of the Dem base — cushioned by its size.
- Surge skews young but slightly Republican.** New-to-2025G referendum voters were 11.8% of Rep voters vs 9.8% of Dems — Democrats lost more of their base *and* replaced less of it.
- Re-mobilization target:** young, Dem-leaning 2025 voters — highest volume in Fairfax / Loudoun / Prince William and overwhelmingly Democratic there (Fairfax: ~81k Dem vs ~19k Rep), highest rate in college towns (Harrisonburg, Charlottesville, Williamsburg). Voter-level list available (held privately, VAN-ready).

Eligibility note: the youngest surge band is modestly inflated by ~5,400 voters who turned 18 after the 2025 General (eligible for the referendum, not 2025G) — only 1.6% of all surge. Excluding them, the 18–24 surge rate is 22.8% rather than 24.9%, so the young tilt is overwhelmingly genuine. Source: 2025-General vote history and 2026 referendum participation matched in the VAN voter file (Van party ID + Dem-support score). "Drop-off" and "surge" are limited to voters present in VAN; ~25k referendum voters with no VAN record (new registrations) are additional surge. Aggregate counts only — no individual voter data. Detail: analysis/LTV2026_Ref_Analysis.md §5i–5j.